

Many children have fantasies about era-defining sporting achievements. For most, it doesn't go much beyond that.

Not for Mondo. The 24-year-old won the Olympic gold medal, set the Olympic record, and then broke the world record — in that order. He also holds nine of the ten best vaults of all time.

As for the Olympic gold medal, it

Ethereal act: As Mondo sprinted down the runway, it indeed felt like he had God's hand behind him. REUTERS

first came in Tokyo — a competition Mondo would describe as a “high-pressure practice session”.

At the Stade de France, when he had the height of the pole vault bar set at 6.25m — one centimetre more than his previous world record — he had the entire crowd of over 69,000 people cheering him on.

The King of Sweden was also present, along with other royalty, including former Ukrainian pole vaulter Sergey Bubka, whose tapes Mondo would watch obsessively as a child.

The adoration of the

crowd was a given. He also had his competitors, those who might have once wanted to beat him, asking the crowd to get even more behind him than it already was.

What sets the pole vault (and also the high jump) apart from other athletics events is that spectators already know, even before the task is attempted, exactly what is being accomplished. It builds up the drama like no other track and field event.

No one does suspense like Mondo. No one seems to do the pole vault like him either.

